

Far-Right Speeches and Emotional Contagion in Parliament

Sequential and Multimodal Evidence from Germany

Christian Arnold
University of Birmingham

Andreas Kuepfer
TU Darmstadt

Christian Stecker
TU Darmstadt

Annual Meeting of the European Political Science Society · 18–20 June 2026 · Belfast, UK

The Question and the Existing Answer

Does far-right parliamentary success make democratic debate more negative?

The Question and the Existing Answer

Does far-right parliamentary success make democratic debate more negative?

Valentim & Widmann (2023)

- AfD entry into German state parliaments
- Established parties **do not** imitate far-right negativity
- Instead: **more positive** emotional language
- Interpretation: rhetorical distancing from a norm-breaking actor

The Question and the Existing Answer

Does far-right parliamentary success make democratic debate more negative?

Valentim & Widmann (2023)

- AfD entry into German state parliaments
- Established parties **do not** imitate far-right negativity
- Instead: **more positive** emotional language
- Interpretation: rhetorical distancing from a norm-breaking actor

But this is an average, entry-level, text-based result

- Aggregates across speeches and time
- Cannot reveal *immediate* reactions within debates
- Cannot capture *how* responses are delivered

What the Average Misses

The Sequential Dimension

Parliamentary debate is *ordered*: speeches respond to prior speeches within agenda items.

- What happens **immediately following** an AfD speech?
- Expected: anger ↑, positive language ↓; even if the aggregate is positive

What the Average Misses

The Sequential Dimension

Parliamentary debate is *ordered*: speeches respond to prior speeches within agenda items.

- What happens **immediately following** an AfD speech?
- Expected: anger ↑, positive language ↓; even if the aggregate is positive

The Multimodal Dimension

Speech is not only text: legislators communicate through pitch, head movement, and gestures.

- Do responses become **vocally and visually activated**?
- Are these channels coupled, or do they move independently?
- Expected: text follows text, pitch follows pitch, visuals follow visuals

Research Design and Case Selection

Research design



Research Design and Case Selection

Research design



Case Selection

Parliament	Period	AfD from
Hesse	2013–2025	2019
Saxony-Anhalt	2021–2025	2021
Saxony	2019–2025	2019
Baden-Württemberg	2011–2025	2016
Bundestag	2017–2025	2017

49,662 speeches · 7,615 AfD speeches · ~15,000 hours of video

Measurement Framework

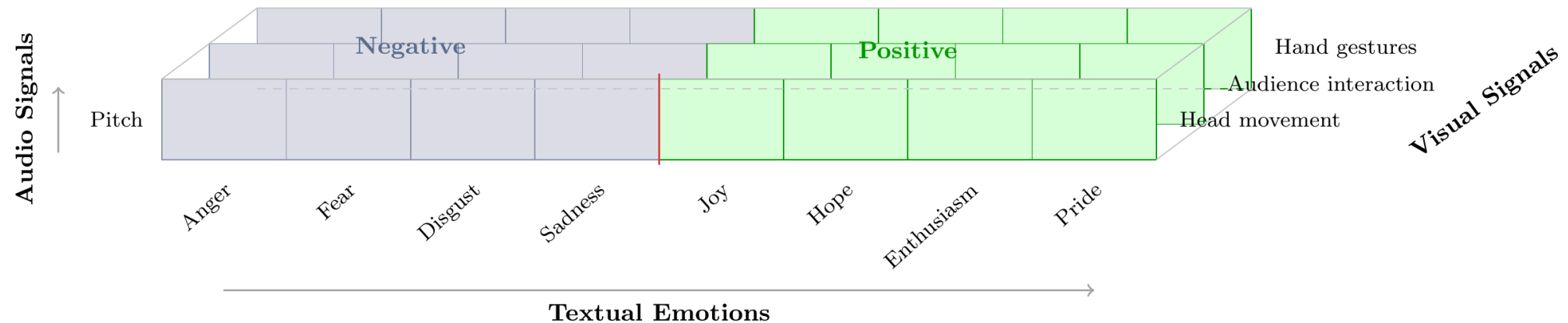
Three dimensions:

- **Text** (8 discrete emotions: anger, fear, disgust, sadness; joy, hope, enthusiasm, pride)
- **Audio** (pitch F0 mean)
- **Visual** (head movement, audience interaction, hand gestures)

Measurement Framework

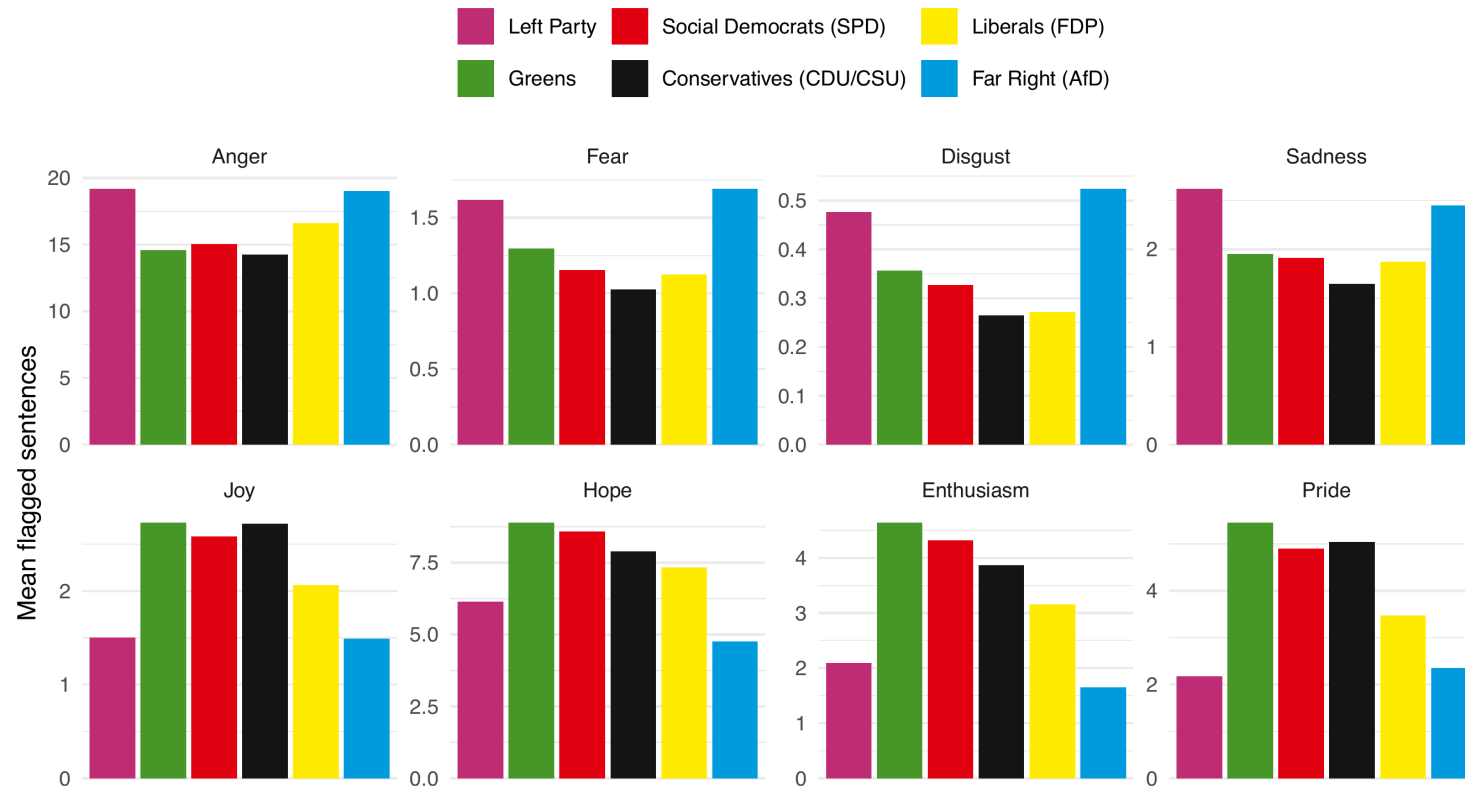
Three dimensions:

- **Text** (8 discrete emotions: anger, fear, disgust, sadness; joy, hope, enthusiasm, pride)
- **Audio** (pitch F0 mean)
- **Visual** (head movement, audience interaction, hand gestures)



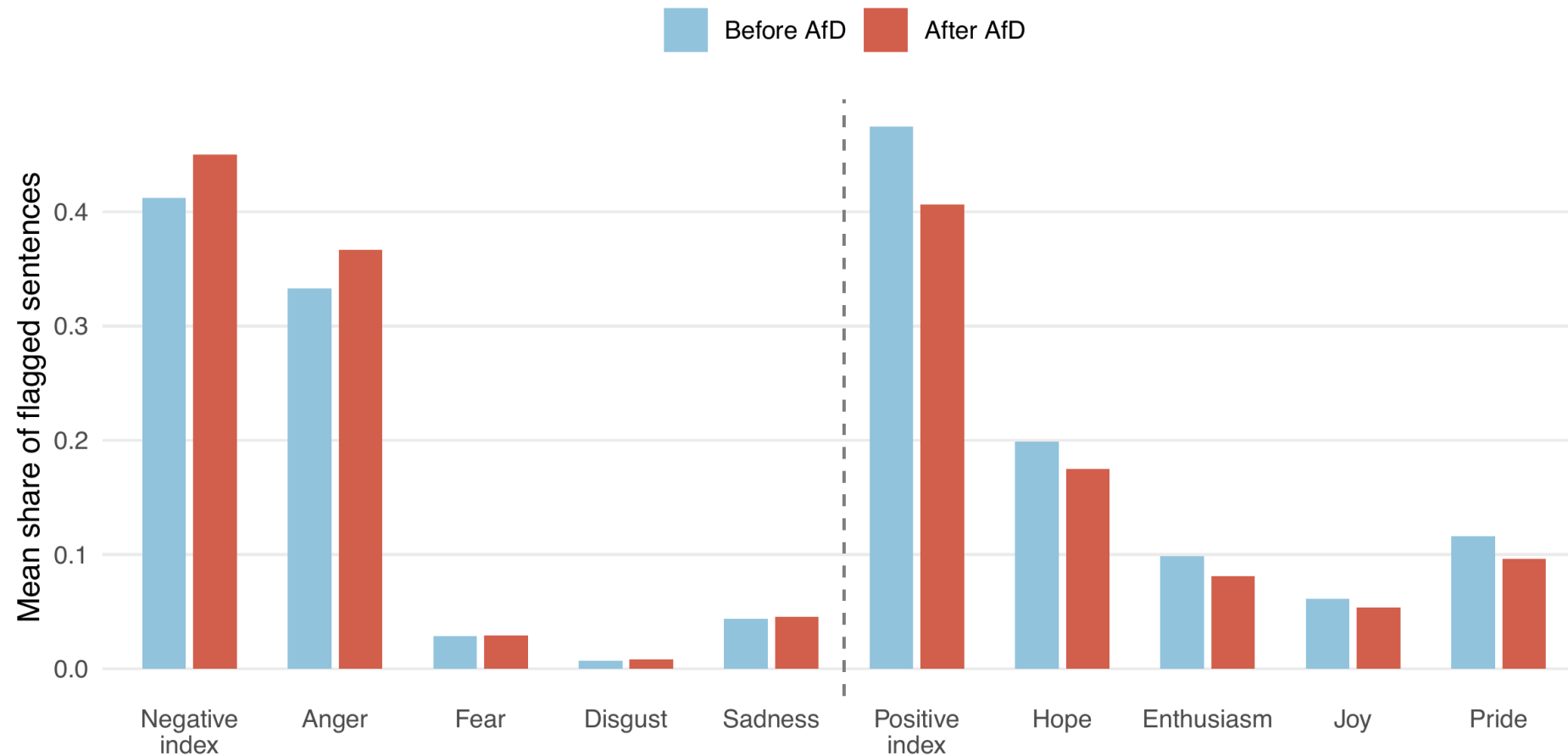
Result 1: Average Distancing

H1: Average semantic distancing: non-AfD parties respond to AfD presence with more positive language (replication)



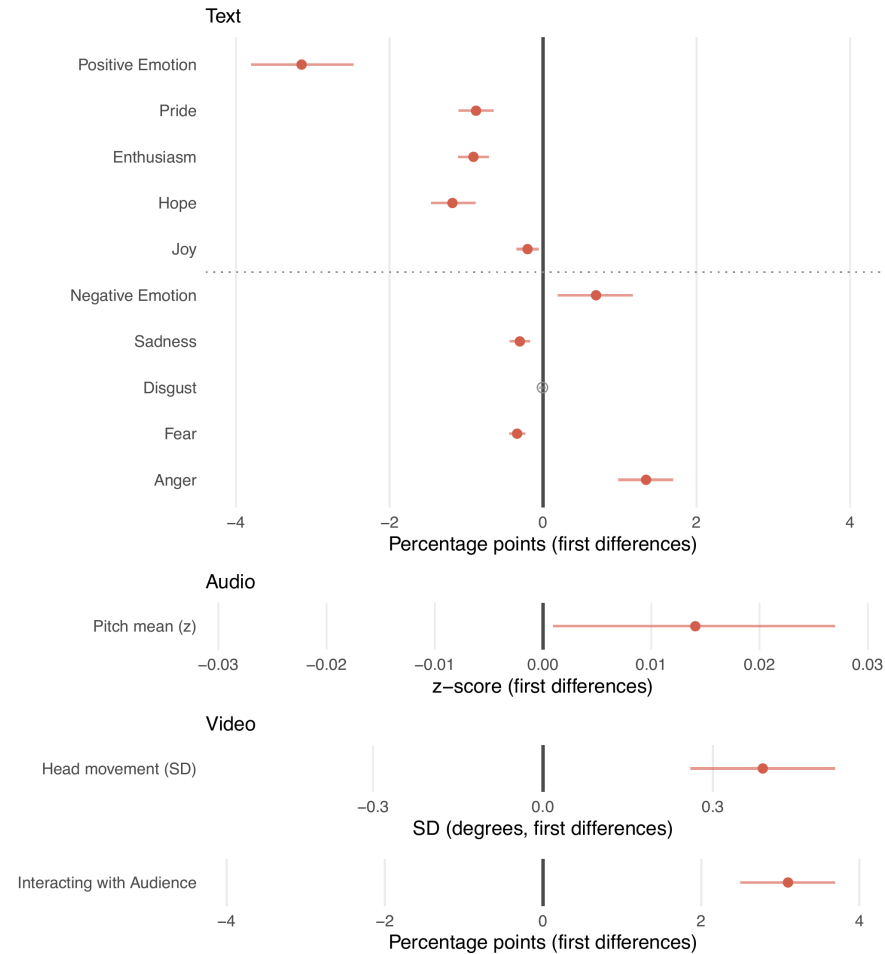
Result 2: Average vs. Sequential

H2: Sequential mirroring: speeches *after* AfD interventions contain more anger and less positive language (descriptive)



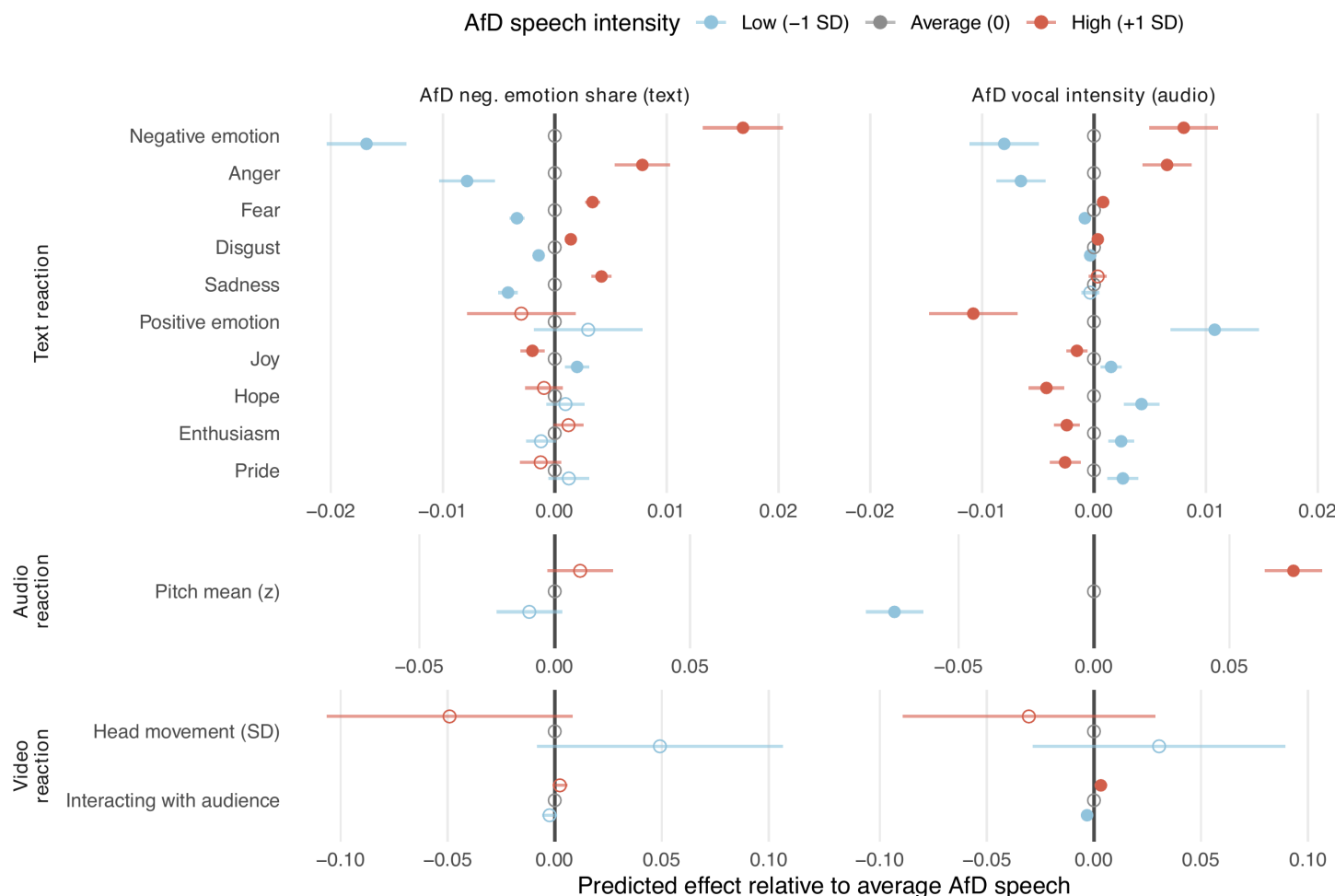
Result 2: Average vs. Sequential

H2: Sequential mirroring: speeches *after* AfD interventions contain more anger and less positive language (modelled)



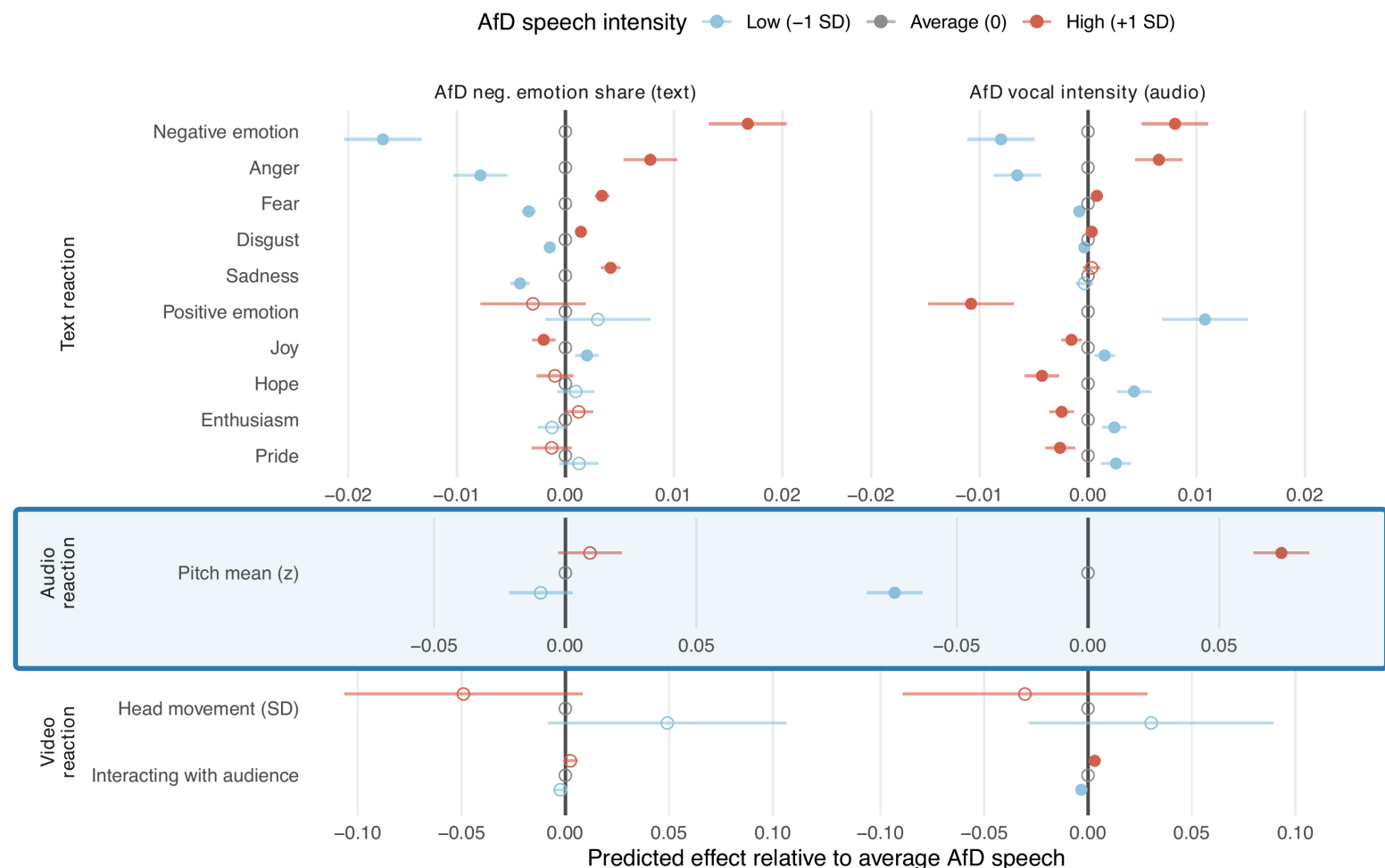
Result 3: Modality-Specific Transmission

H3: Vocally intense far right → pitch elevation (Audio); negative emotions far right → more anger in text (Text)



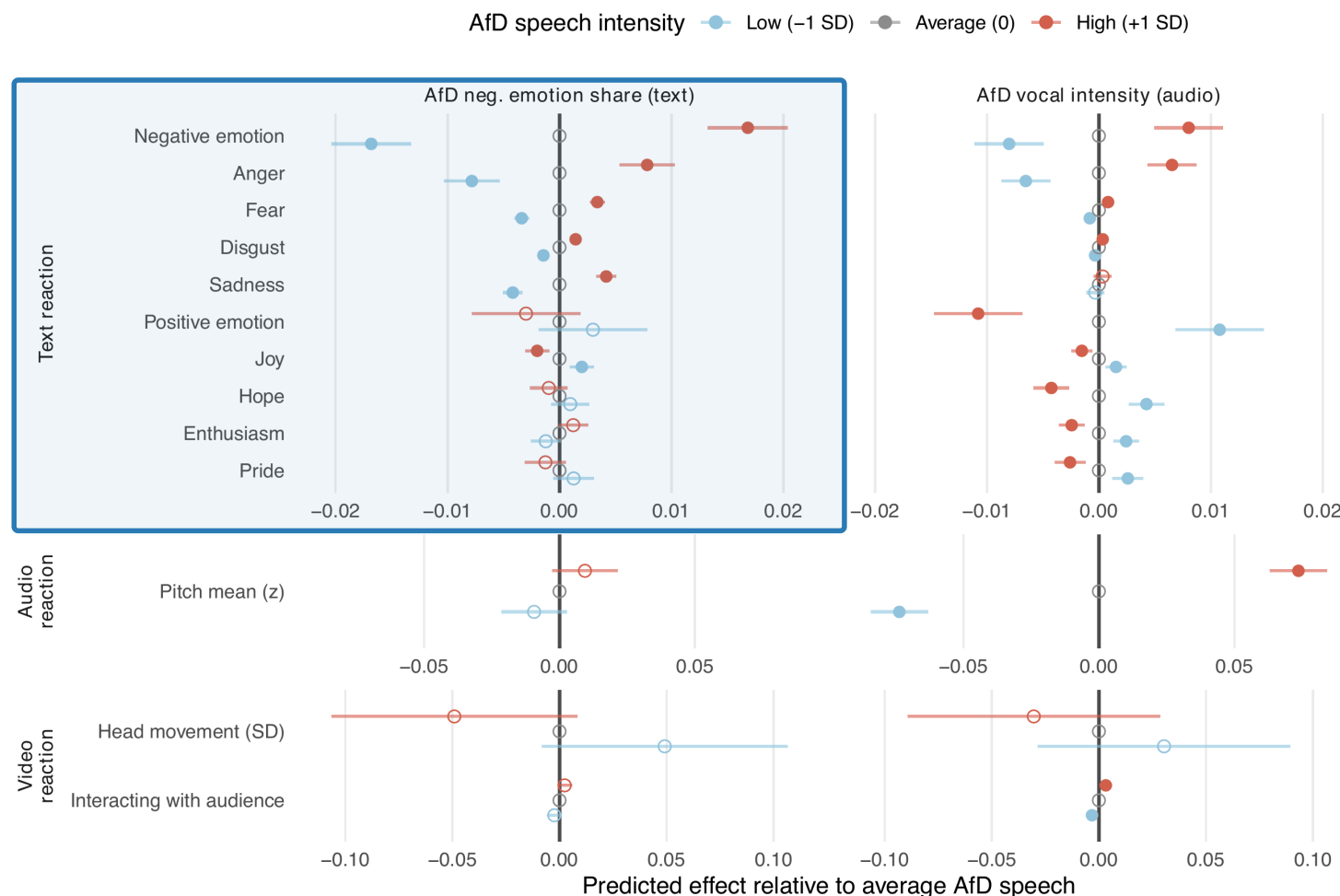
Result 3: Modality-Specific Transmission

H3: Vocally intense far right → pitch elevation (Audio); negative emotions far right → more anger in text (Text)



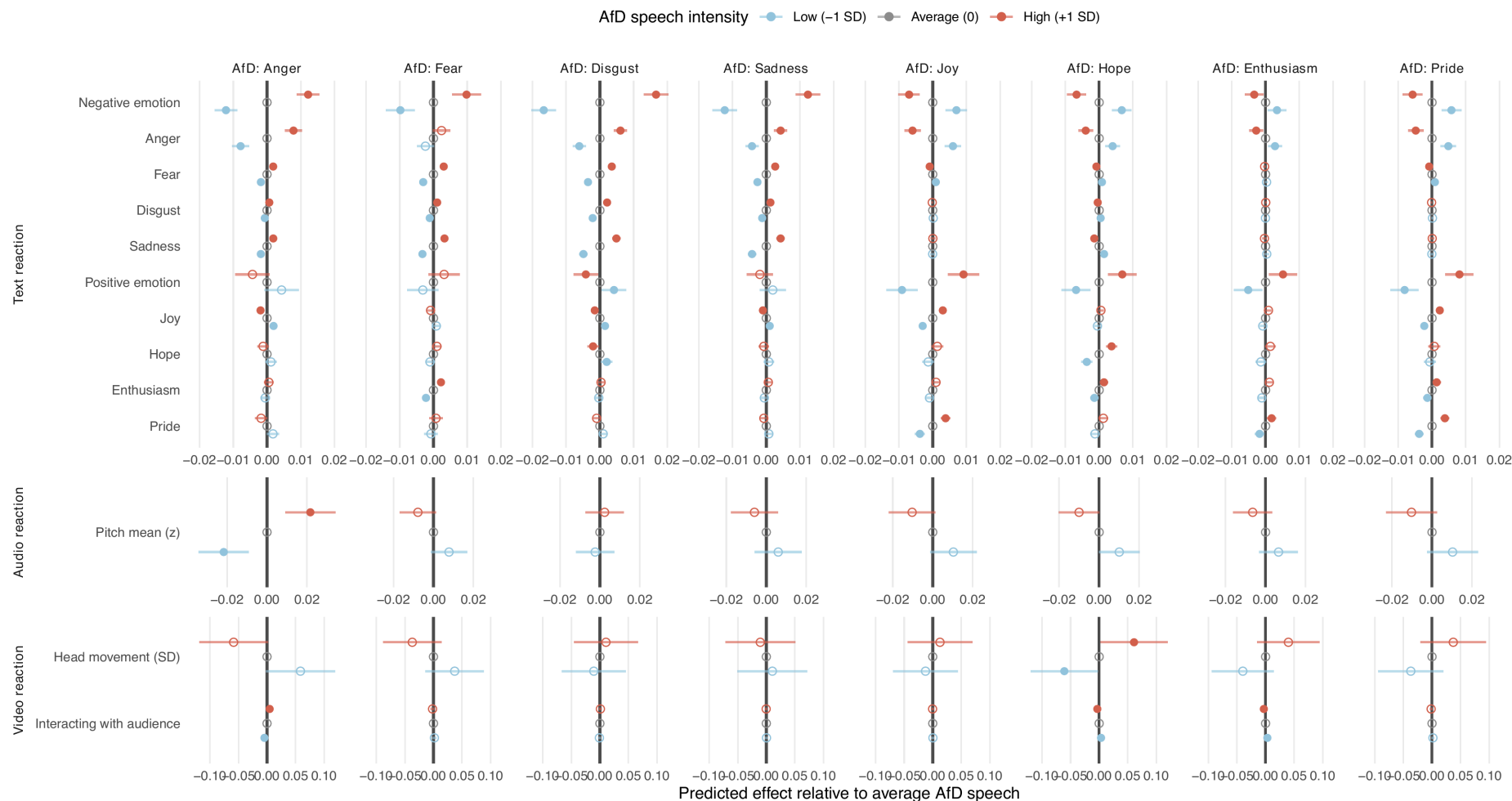
Result 3: Modality-Specific Transmission

H3: Vocally intense far right → pitch elevation (Audio); negative emotions far right → more anger in text (Text)



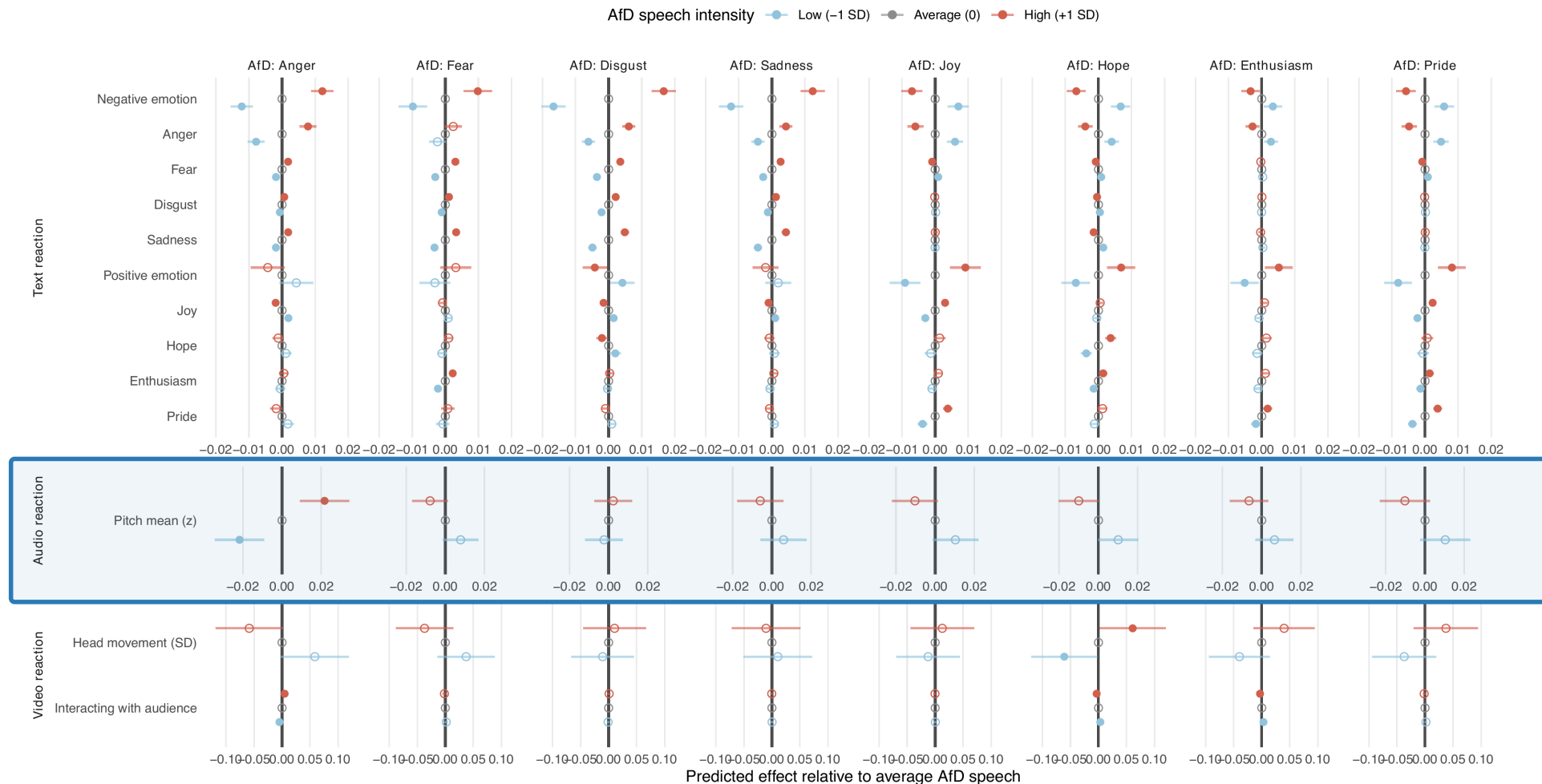
Result 4: Emotion-Specific Coupling

H4a Increased far right anger → pitch elevation; **H4b** Positive (negative) emotions transmit positive (negative) responses



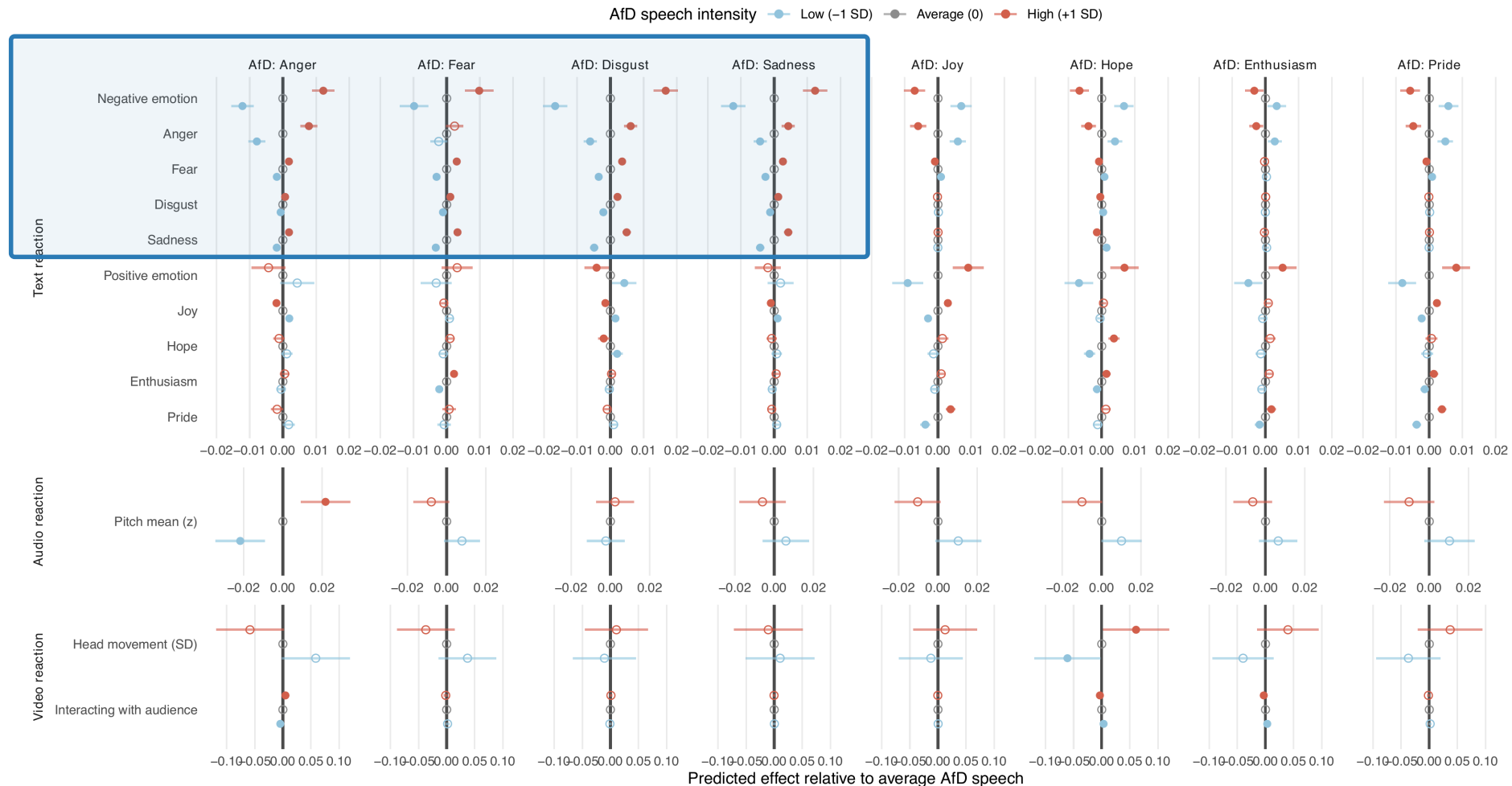
Result 4: Emotion-Specific Coupling

H4a Increased far right anger → pitch elevation; **H4b** Positive (negative) emotions transmit positive (negative) responses



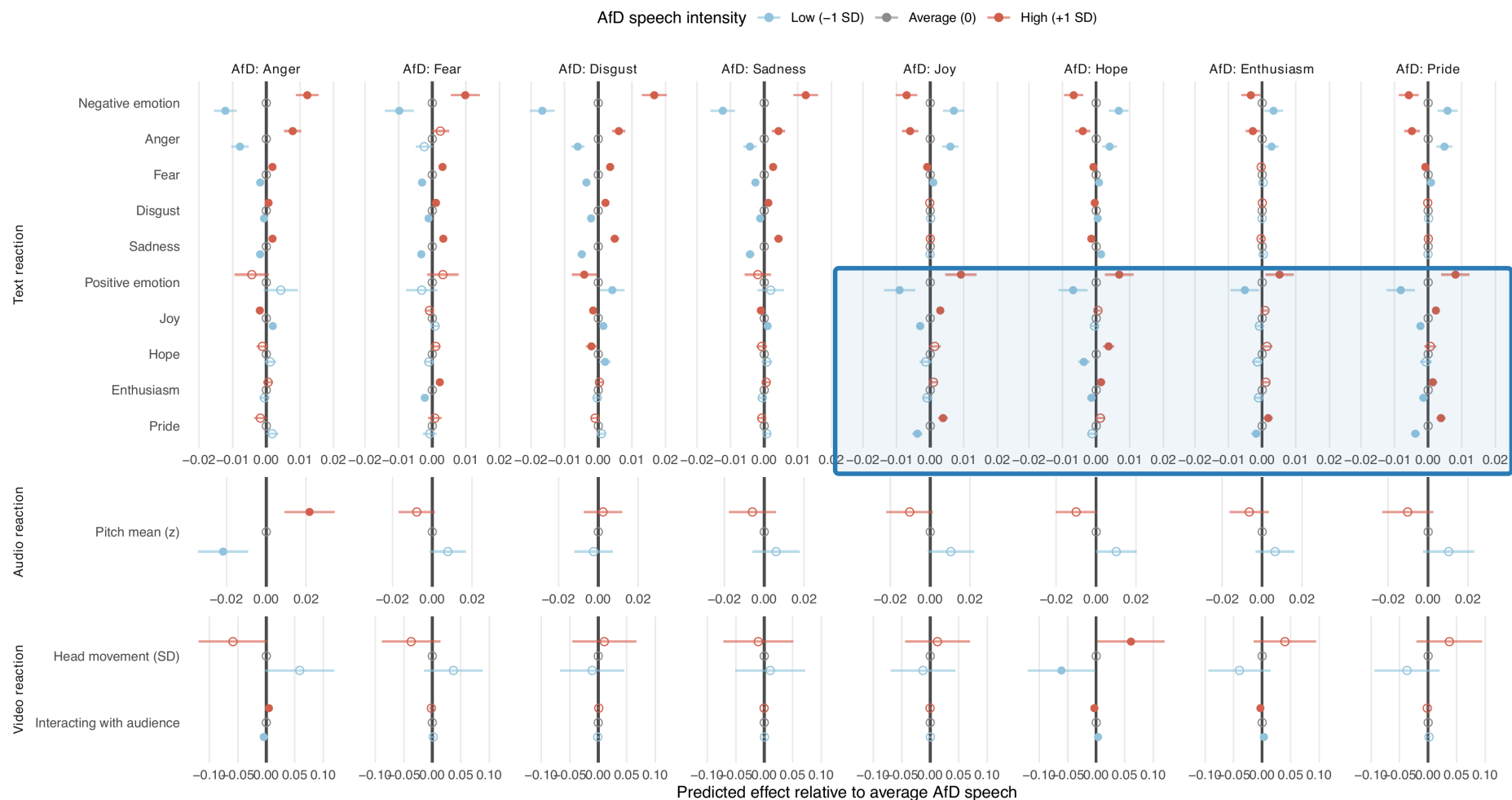
Result 4: Emotion-Specific Coupling

H4a Increased far right anger → pitch elevation; **H4b** Positive (negative) emotions transmit positive (negative) responses



Result 4: Emotion-Specific Coupling

H4a Increased far right anger → pitch elevation; **H4b** Positive (negative) emotions transmit positive (negative) responses



Takeaways & Next Steps

Findings

Takeaways & Next Steps

Findings

1. Level-dependence: Average distancing and sequential mirroring coexist; they operate at different levels of analysis

Takeaways & Next Steps

Findings

- 1. Level-dependence:** Average distancing and sequential mirroring coexist; they operate at different levels of analysis
- 2. Modality-specificity:** Vocal activation follows vocal; text follows text; not a uniform contagion process

Takeaways & Next Steps

Findings

- 1. Level-dependence:** Average distancing and sequential mirroring coexist; they operate at different levels of analysis
- 2. Modality-specificity:** Vocal activation follows vocal; text follows text; not a uniform contagion process
- 3. Emotion-specificity:** Anger is the discrete emotion most tightly coupled with pitch elevation

Takeaways & Next Steps

Findings

- 1. Level-dependence:** Average distancing and sequential mirroring coexist; they operate at different levels of analysis
- 2. Modality-specificity:** Vocal activation follows vocal; text follows text; not a uniform contagion process
- 3. Emotion-specificity:** Anger is the discrete emotion most tightly coupled with pitch elevation
→ Far-right presence creates **repeated, localised episodes** of emotion- and modality-specific mirroring: locally intense, hard to detect in aggregate

Takeaways & Next Steps

Findings

- 1. Level-dependence:** Average distancing and sequential mirroring coexist; they operate at different levels of analysis
- 2. Modality-specificity:** Vocal activation follows vocal; text follows text; not a uniform contagion process
- 3. Emotion-specificity:** Anger is the discrete emotion most tightly coupled with pitch elevation
→ Far-right presence creates **repeated, localised episodes** of emotion- and modality-specific mirroring: locally intense, hard to detect in aggregate

Next Steps

Takeaways & Next Steps

Findings

- 1. Level-dependence:** Average distancing and sequential mirroring coexist; they operate at different levels of analysis
- 2. Modality-specificity:** Vocal activation follows vocal; text follows text; not a uniform contagion process
- 3. Emotion-specificity:** Anger is the discrete emotion most tightly coupled with pitch elevation
→ Far-right presence creates **repeated, localised episodes** of emotion- and modality-specific mirroring: locally intense, hard to detect in aggregate

Next Steps

Expand corpus: extend to all 16 German state parliaments and Bundestag

Takeaways & Next Steps

Findings

- 1. Level-dependence:** Average distancing and sequential mirroring coexist; they operate at different levels of analysis
 - 2. Modality-specificity:** Vocal activation follows vocal; text follows text; not a uniform contagion process
 - 3. Emotion-specificity:** Anger is the discrete emotion most tightly coupled with pitch elevation
- Far-right presence creates **repeated, localised episodes** of emotion- and modality-specific mirroring: locally intense, hard to detect in aggregate

Next Steps

- Expand corpus:** extend to all 16 German state parliaments and Bundestag
- Expand visual layer:** hand gestures not yet in models; next iteration incorporates the complete measurement matrix

Takeaways & Next Steps

Findings

- 1. Level-dependence:** Average distancing and sequential mirroring coexist; they operate at different levels of analysis
- 2. Modality-specificity:** Vocal activation follows vocal; text follows text; not a uniform contagion process
- 3. Emotion-specificity:** Anger is the discrete emotion most tightly coupled with pitch elevation
→ Far-right presence creates **repeated, localised episodes** of emotion- and modality-specific mirroring: locally intense, hard to detect in aggregate

Next Steps

- Expand corpus:** extend to all 16 German state parliaments and Bundestag
- Expand visual layer:** hand gestures not yet in models; next iteration incorporates the complete measurement matrix
- Causal identification:** DiD using the pre-AfD-entry period as control; shifts in the post-AfD window vs. baseline behaviour before AfD entered parliament

Far-Right Speeches and Emotional Contagion in Parliament: Sequential and Multimodal Evidence from Germany

Christian Arnold · Andreas Kuepfer · Christian Stecker

Contact:

andreaskuepfer.github.io
andreas.kuepfer@tu-darmstadt.de
[ankuepfer@bsky.social](https://bsky.social/ankuepfer)